THE GHOSTWRITER FROM THE 6TH DIMENSION

FEATURE SCREENPLAY

Written by

[Writer]

Original screenplay
Draft 1, complete. Built from the three act files by tools/build_full_script.py.
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FADE IN:

BLACK.

Rain on a slate roof. Hundreds of small, dry clicks.

SUPER: "AUGUST 14, 1987"

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

A boy's hand writes in pencil in a green cloth notebook. Pale skin. Graphite smears the edge of his palm.

On the cover: THE MARGIN. Below it: BY THEODORE LINDQVIST. PRIVATE.

The handwriting, round and careful:

> *Behind the pond there is a door. Behind the door is the back of everything. Whatever is lost goes there. Whatever is forgotten waits.*

The pencil pauses. Starts again:

> *Theodore put his ear to the door and*

The kitchen: yellow linoleum, a scarred wooden table, a round white clock over the back door reading 3:05. A plastic radio on the counter plays low.

RADIO DJ (V.O.)
...five past three on a wet Friday, you're with WRUT Rutland, and if you were planning a picnic, don't.

THEO (9) writes with his back to the screen door, hair hanging over his face.

The screen door bangs. Small bare feet slap across the linoleum and stop beside his chair. A five-year-old's voice:

NELL (O.S.)
Theo?

His pencil keeps moving.

NELL (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Will you come see the door?

THEO (9)
In a minute.

NELL (O.S.)
You said after lunch.

THEO (9)
I know. In a minute.

His pencil keeps moving. Nell's bare feet stand beside his chair.

NELL (O.S.)
Okay.

Her feet slap away. The screen door springs shut.

The clock's second hand sweeps. The page fills with handwriting.

Outside, the rain thins to a few clicks, then stops. The radio is the only sound. The clock reads 3:26.

RADIO DJ (V.O.)
...clearing over the valley now.
Twenty-six past three.

Theo sets the pencil down. He turns in his chair.

The kitchen is empty. The back door stands open an inch.

Two sets of small wet footprints cross the linoleum, from the door to his chair and back out. The outgoing prints are one stride apart: a walk, not a run.

THEO (9)
Nell?

Water drips from the eaves. No answer.

A drop of water lands on the notebook page. The pencil lines blur and run.

BLACK.

THE GHOSTWRITER FROM THE 6TH DIMENSION

SUPER: "THIRTY-EIGHT YEARS LATER"

INT. STATION WAGON - MOVING - DAY

Rain taps the roof. Hundreds of small, dry clicks.

A ten-year-old station wagon packed to the roof. Boxes labeled in neat block capitals: JUNE - SCHOOL. JUNE - OTHER. THEO - BOOKS (DON'T).

THEO LINDQVIST (47) drives, long pale fingers drumming the wheel. Tall, stooped, three days of stubble, a good wool coat gone shiny at the elbows.

JUNE (12) sits beside him in an oversized hoodie, a laptop open on her knees. She watches Theo, not the screen.

Public radio plays low.

HOST (V.O.)
...from our archive. The winter Theo Lindqvist's debut, "Slate," won everything it was eligible for. It opens on a boy at a kitchen table while, across the valley, something terrible happens. Did you have that afternoon?

YOUNG THEO (V.O.)
I was home. I was nine, writing at the kitchen table, and I felt it. You know how you can feel a door open somewhere in a house? I felt it in the kitchen. I didn't know what I'd felt until they came home.

Theo reaches for the dial. June turns the volume up first.

HOST (V.O.)
You've said you don't write your books. You take dictation.

YOUNG THEO (V.O.)
I just try to be in the room when they arrive.

HOST (V.O.)
And if they don't?

YOUNG THEO (V.O.)
They always arrive.

June switches the radio off.

JUNE
You sound like you're about to win something.

THEO
I did win something.

JUNE
That's what I mean. So what happens when they don't?

THEO
When what doesn't?

JUNE
Arrive.

Theo smiles a second too late.

THEO
Your mother's been talking.

JUNE
Mom says you've been "between books" since I was four.

THEO
Your mother is gifted at euphemism.

JUNE
It's not a euphemism. It's a quote.

The dash screen lights up: PRIYA RAMAN - EDITOR. Theo watches it ring. It stops. ONE NEW VOICEMAIL. June taps PLAY.

THEO
June.

JUNE
It's a public car.

PRIYA (V.O.)
Theo, it's Priya. I'm not calling about the deadline. I'm calling about the deadline. December first. Legal has started saying "advance" in a tone. I don't need a book. I need pages. Read me one sentence out loud, like you used to. One. Call me. I love you. Call me.

Theo keeps his eyes on the road.

JUNE
Mom bet me ten dollars you'd say "in a minute" before we got there.

THEO
Did she.

JUNE
I took the other side.

She turns the laptop toward him.

JUNE (CONT'D)
It's eleven pages. It's a ghost story with a lighthouse. Will you read it?

Theo's drumming fingers stop.

THEO
In a minute.

June closes the laptop with both hands. She looks out her window.

JUNE
That's ten dollars.

The road runs along the rim of a quarry. Gray slate shelves step down to a black pond. Rain falls on the pond. The surface stays smooth: no rings, no ripples.

A gravel turnout. A granite slab with bleached plastic flowers and a mason jar of fresh orange marigolds.

June twists in her seat to read it as they pass.

JUNE (CONT'D)
"Tomas Arvidsen. Nineteen seventy-four to nineteen eighty-seven. He reached for her."
Who's Tomas Arvidsen?

THEO
A boy who lived down the road.

JUNE
He was thirteen.

THEO
He pulled my sister out of that pond. He didn't come out himself.

JUNE
Aunt Nell.

THEO
Yes.

JUNE
Are we stopping?

THEO
No.

June faces front.

JUNE
Okay.

The slab shrinks in the rearview mirror. Theo's fingers drum the wheel.

EXT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - DAY

A white clapboard farmhouse with a gray slate roof at the top of a gravel lane. A FOR SALE sign leans against the porch rail.

Beyond the field, the quarry's rim cuts a flat line across the sky.

The station wagon rolls up and stops. The engine ticks. Neither of them gets out.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

The same kitchen: yellow linoleum, a scarred wooden table, a round white clock over the back door, a plastic radio on the counter.

Gray dust coats everything. White sheets cover two chairs.

Theo stops in the doorway. June walks past him, opens the refrigerator, waves a hand in front of her nose, shuts it.

JUNE
It smells like a library that died.

THEO
Your grandmother was a librarian.

JUNE
Then it's accurate. There's a jar in there that used to be a pickle.

A photograph hangs on the refrigerator door under a lobster-shaped magnet. Theo at nine, all elbows, squints into the sun.

Beside him a taller boy straddles a bicycle in a red jacket, freckled hands on the handlebars. The magnet covers the taller boy's face.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Who's that?

THEO
Me.

JUNE
The other one.

THEO
A neighbor.

June reaches for the magnet. Theo's hand closes over hers.

THEO (CONT'D)
Bedrooms are upstairs. Pick one.

June looks at his hand on hers. He lifts it away.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - DAY

A forty-foot hall of worn floorboards, coat pegs along one wall.

Halfway down on the left, a door sits an inch deeper in its doorway than the others. A card thumbtacked to it reads CELLAR.

On the right, an archway to a sitting room with a dark wood-cabinet TV. At the far end, a white door, its seam filled with layers of paint.

June walks past the stairs. She goes down the hall, passes the cellar door, and stops at the white door. She turns the knob. It turns. The door doesn't move.

JUNE
It's painted shut.

Theo stands in the kitchen doorway at the other end.

THEO
It's cold-weather storage.

JUNE
Whose room was it?

THEO
Storage, June.

JUNE
That's not a whose.

THEO
Nobody's.

A floorboard creaks on the other side of the white door. June and Theo look at each other.

THEO (CONT'D)
Old house. Upstairs. Pick a bed.

June looks at the door again, then walks past him toward the stairs.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

One lamp. Theo sits at the table with a legal pad, a mug of tea, and a pen. The refrigerator hums.

He closes his eyes and rests the pen on the first line. Thirty seconds pass. The refrigerator motor clicks off.

He opens his eyes. The page is blank. He writes IT WAS. Stares at it. Crosses it out.

From inside the wall behind the stove: the dry scratch of a pencil on paper. Strokes, a pause, strokes.

Theo stands and presses his ear to the plaster. The scratching travels along the wall toward the hall. He follows it three steps. It stops when he stops.

THEO
Hello?

No answer. A pipe knocks. Theo breathes out a laugh and returns to the table.

He sits and closes his eyes. The scratching starts again, softer. His shoulders drop. His head sinks onto his folded arms.

A stair creaks. June stands at the bottom of the stairs in socks and a long T-shirt, holding a glass of water. She looks at Theo asleep at the table.

She takes his coat from the chair back and drapes it over his shoulders. She tears a corner off the legal pad and writes on it. The scrap reads:

DAD - 11 PAGES. WHENEVER. -J.

She adds a smiley face. Crosses it out. Slides the scrap under his mug and goes upstairs.

The scratching in the wall continues.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MORNING

Gray light. Birds. Theo lifts his head, a crease from his sleeve across his cheek.

Beside the legal pad lies a single sheet of cream paper with faded green rules and a deckled edge.

A child's round handwriting covers it in brown-black ink. The ink glistens.

Theo reads, lips moving.

The slate was cold on my teeth.
That is the first thing. I want to tell it in order.
It was Friday and it was raining and the kitchen smelled like wet stone. I was writing. Nell asked me to come see the door and I said in a minute.
I did not look up.

He touches the page. His fingertips come away wet. He holds them to his nose.

He takes a children's atlas from the shelf and opens the cover. In faded pencil: THEODORE LINDQVIST - GRADE 4.

The crossbars of its t's float above the stems, the same as on the page.

Theo tests the back door: bolted from inside. The windows: latched. The front door: chained.

He returns to the table. He picks up June's scrap, reads it, folds it, and puts it in his shirt pocket.

JUNE (O.S.)
What?

June stands in the doorway with a cereal box, hair flat on one side.

THEO
Did you write this?

He holds out the page. June comes closer and reads. Her lips move on the last line.

JUNE
That's not me. I write like I'm twelve, not nine.

THEO
It isn't a joke, June.

JUNE
I know it isn't. You went white.

She looks at the page, then at him.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Is it from your book?

THEO
No.

JUNE
Then who wrote it?

THEO
I don't know.

He turns the page over. The paper is buckled. Faint, reversed lines of the same handwriting show through the back. He holds it up to the window.

THEO (CONT'D)
Bleed-through.

JUNE
I didn't ask.

Theo slides the page inside a paperback on his mother's shelf: SLATE, by Theo Lindqvist, a prize sticker on its spine.

Two more of his novels stand beside it, spines aligned.

He presses his palm flat against the row of books.

INT. ALDER HILL MEMORY CARE - DAYROOM - DAY

Tall windows and a pair of glass doors face a rainy garden. A MAN stands at a window, hands clasped behind him.

Two WOMEN at a table match socks beside a half-finished jigsaw puzzle.

At a corner table INGRID LINDQVIST (79) folds washcloths: tiny, upright, white braid pinned on top of her head, cardigan buttoned one hole off.

A basin of water sits at her elbow. She dips a cloth, wrings it, folds it in thirds, stacks it.

INGRID
One in. Two in.

Theo crouches beside her chair, his back to the room. June stands behind him.

THEO
Mom.

Ingrid looks up and beams. She cups his face in her wet hands.

INGRID
Tomas! Look at you. You'll catch your death.

THEO
It's Theo, Mom.

Ingrid frowns and lets go.

INGRID
Theo's at the table. Theo's writing.

THEO
Some days.

She goes back to the washcloths.

INGRID
Tomas came back wet. Theo came back dry. I counted them both in.

At the word "wet," everyone in the room turns toward the glass doors. The man at the window. The two women. A woman with a walker in the doorway.

Then they all turn back.

June watches the residents, then the back of her father's head.

INGRID (CONT'D)
One in. Two in.
(to June)
And who's this?

JUNE
I'm June.

INGRID
You look like the other librarian.

JUNE
My mom's a conservator.

INGRID
That's what I said.

June smiles.

ELLIE (43) pushes a medication cart into the room. Navy scrubs, a name tag reading ELLIE M., RN, reading glasses on a chain. A pale band on her bare ring finger.

Ellie's face blurs whenever Theo looks at it. His eyes slide to her name tag, the cart, the window.

ELLIE
Afternoon meds, Mrs. L.

INGRID
She's always on time.

THEO
(to Ellie's name tag)
I thought the night nurse--

ELLIE
I'm covering.

Ingrid watches Theo look at the name tag.

INGRID
He doesn't see you, does he.

Ellie hands Ingrid a paper cup of pills.

ELLIE
She's tired, Mr. Lindqvist.

THEO
Of course.

ELLIE
Her windows are getting shorter. Mornings are best.

THEO
I'll try mornings.

ELLIE
Try.

THEO
We're selling the house. For the permanent wing.

Ellie looks straight at him.

ELLIE
Then come while she still knows what a house is.

EXT. ALDER HILL - PARKING LOT - DAY

Drizzle. Theo digs for his keys. June stands on the passenger side with her hood up.

JUNE
She counted two.

THEO
Two what?

JUNE
You and the other one. Every time. "One in. Two in."

THEO
She was folding washcloths.

JUNE
She said "both."

Theo gets in the car. June stays outside in the rain until he starts the engine.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT

The hall is dark. Light from the kitchen doorway lies across the floorboards.

Theo stands in the doorway in socks, a mug in his hand. A drip hits the floor somewhere down the hall. Another.

He flips the switch. A bare bulb lights the hall.

He walks to the cellar door and stops. Drip. He lays his palm flat against the wood.

THEO
Pipes.

He turns and walks back toward the kitchen. The dripping stops.

Behind him, at the foot of the cellar door, a wet footprint forms on the dry boards: bare, narrow, twelve inches long. Water wells up inside its outline.

Theo keeps walking. A second print forms a stride beyond the first. A third. One print every half second, heading down the hall toward the white door.

Theo steps through the kitchen doorway. A refrigerator door opens, then shuts.

The prints keep forming. The last print forms in front of the white door. Water seeps out beneath it and runs along the seam.

Under the floor: the scratch of a pencil.

A single wet slap against the white door.

Theo returns to the doorway with a milk carton in his hand. He looks down the hall. His fingers open. The carton hits the floor.

The prints run the length of the hall, from the cellar door to the white door.

He walks along them. He touches the first print with two fingers, holds them to his nose, looks at his socks. Dry.

At the white door he grips the knob. Water drips from it. He lets go and wipes his palm on his shirt.

He fetches a mop from the kitchen and mops the prints, hard and fast, from the cellar door to the white door. He mops longest in front of the white door.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - SITTING ROOM - NIGHT

The wood-cabinet TV sits dark. In its screen: a dim reflection of the lit hall.

In the reflection, Theo reaches for the light switch. Behind him, at the far end of the hall beside the white door, a tall, narrow figure stands dripping.

It is there for half a second.

Click. The hall goes dark. The screen goes black.

Under the floor, one long stroke of a pencil.

INT. SLATE DINER - MORNING

A narrow room: a counter, six booths, a framed 1952 photograph of quarrymen in caps lined up on a slate shelf. A mug sits in front of every regular.

Theo and June sit at the counter. June cuts pancakes into squares. Theo sips coffee over a blank legal pad. A WAITRESS (60s) refills his cup.

WALTER PRUITT (74) takes the stool one down from Theo: tweed jacket, hearing aid, ink stains on his cuffs. The waitress sets a coffee in front of him without being asked.

WALTER
Forgive me. You're Theo Lindqvist.

THEO
Depends who's asking.

WALTER
Nobody important. Walter Pruitt. Quarry Road, three doors past you. I read "Slate" twice, which is once more than I read most of what I wrote.

THEO
You're a writer.

WALTER
I was a ghostwriter. It's different. A writer wants to be read. A ghost wants to be believed.

JUNE
What's a ghostwriter?

WALTER
Someone who writes the book you think someone else wrote. Forty-one of them, in my case. Senators. Quarterbacks. A woman who'd been married to three of the four men she says she met in Paris. Not a name on one of them.

JUNE
That's the saddest job I've ever heard.

WALTER
It has compensations. Nobody can ever blame you.

June looks at Theo. Theo stares into his coffee.

WALTER (CONT'D)
You're writing again. By hand.

THEO
I'm not writing.

WALTER
I heard it from my porch. Pencil. All night, from your house.

THEO
I don't use a pencil.

Walter's spoon stops.

WALTER
No. I didn't think you did.

He sets the spoon down.

WALTER (CONT'D)
If anyone offers to put a name on it, don't.

THEO
On what?

WALTER
Whatever it is you're not writing.

Theo stands and walks to the register, a bill in his hand.

Behind him, wet bare footprints form on the dry linoleum, one at a time, keeping pace.

The waitress rings up the coffee. The customers keep eating. A man turns a page of his newspaper; a print forms beside his stool.

Walter's cup rattles on its saucer. He sets it down with both hands. The prints stop at the register, beside Theo's left foot.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Oh, you poor boy.

EXT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE LANE - DAY

Afternoon sun after rain. Theo walks down the gravel lane to a rusted tin mailbox and opens it.

Inside: a utility bill, a realtor's flyer, and a cream envelope, damp. No stamp. No postmark. Across the front, in a child's round handwriting:

Theodore

Theo looks up the lane, then down. Empty. His lips shape the name.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Theo sits at the table. The envelope lies open. Two sheets of cream paper, the same brown-black ink, the same child's hand.

He reads. A boy's voice reads with him.

BOY (V.O.)
Nell was in her yellow dress, the one with the ducks. Mom said not to wear it to the quarry. Mom said a lot of things.

EXT. QUARRY POND - DAY (FLASHBACK)

Sun on wet slate, steaming. A flat black pond.

A small girl stands on a stone ledge above the water, facing the pond. Her yellow dress is printed with ducks, all facing the same direction.

BOY (V.O.)
The rain had stopped and the slate was steaming. The pond was perfectly flat. It had no sky in it. Then she wasn't on the ledge anymore.

The ledge is empty. A ring spreads across the water below it.

Freckled hands, a boy's, wade into the pond. On the ledge behind them lies a red jacket.

BOY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I went in. I didn't decide to. It tasted of iron. It tasted like a coin you've held in your mouth all day.

EXT. QUARRY POND - UNDERWATER (FLASHBACK)

Green-black water. Sunlight breaks into coins overhead. A yellow dress sinks. The freckled hands clutch at it and come away with water.

BOY (V.O.)
I had her under the arms and then I didn't. She went out of my hands like something dropped in a well.

A bright rectangle of sky wavers at the surface. The ledge above it is empty.

BOY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I looked up at the ledge for someone to call. There was nobody
(MORE)

BOY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
on the ledge. I looked. I want that written down. I looked.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Theo's finger rests on the page at the line: There was nobody on the ledge. He taps it twice.

His phone buzzes on the table. ALDER HILL.

ELLIE (V.O.)
Mr. Lindqvist? It's Ellie, from Alder Hill. Your mother's asking for you. She's in one of her windows. I thought you'd want to know.

THEO
I'm coming.

He folds the pages into his coat pocket and leaves.

INT. ALDER HILL - INGRID'S ROOM - EVENING

Gold light through the window. A narrow bed.

A shadow box by the door holds a photo of Gunnar in a quarry cap, Ingrid at a library desk, three of Theo's book jackets.

In its lower corner, a rectangle of backing is paler than the rest.

Ingrid sits in an armchair by the window, back straight, hands folded. Her eyes follow Theo across the room.

INGRID
Theo.

Theo sits on the edge of the bed and takes her hand.

INGRID (CONT'D)
You look dreadful. Are you sleeping?

THEO
Not especially.

INGRID
You never did.

THEO
Mom, I need to ask you something. It's about Nell.

Her fingers tighten on his.

THEO (CONT'D)
Do you remember her yellow dress? The one with the ducks?

Ingrid stares at him. She doesn't blink.

INGRID
Where did you get that?

THEO
I read it somewhere.

INGRID
Who told you about the ducks?

THEO
Nobody told me. It was on a page. Someone wrote it down.

Ingrid grips his wrist. Water runs from her cuff down her forearm and drips from her elbow to the floor. Theo flinches.

THEO (CONT'D)
Mom--

INGRID
You weren't there.

THEO
It says I was. It says I went in the water.

INGRID
You weren't there. You were never there. Your father--

Her eyes move to a spot behind Theo's shoulder. Her mouth goes slack.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Are you the man about the piano?

Ellie hurries in with a towel. She kneels and unpeels Ingrid's fingers from Theo's wrist, one at a time.

ELLIE
Okay, Mrs. L. I've got you.

Water drips from Theo's cuff, a wet ring around his wrist. A puddle spreads under Ingrid's chair. Ellie looks at the puddle, then at Theo's wrist. Her face goes blank.

Through the open bathroom door behind her: a dry sink.

ELLIE (CONT'D)
She's been at the sink again. She does that.

Theo looks at the bathroom door, then at the towel in Ellie's hands.

THEO
She said I wasn't there.

ELLIE
She says a lot of things.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The clock reads 11:38. One lamp. The window over the sink is fogged with kettle steam; beyond it, black.

Two cream pages lie on the table. A cup of tea sits untouched. Theo sits and stares at the pages.

THEO
I was home.

Nobody answers. He picks up the second page and reads aloud, low and slow.

THEO (CONT'D)
"I had her under the arms and then I didn't..."

His voice finds a rhythm. His eyes close. His shoulders drop. The corners of his mouth lift.

THEO (CONT'D)
"There was nobody on the ledge. I looked. I want that written down. I looked."

The clock reads 11:39.

THEO (CONT'D)
"There was nobody to take her hand."

His eyes open on the last line of the page. He reads it aloud.

THEO (CONT'D)
"So I reached into the black water
and took her hand, and--"

EXT. QUARRY POND - UNDERWATER (FLASHBACK)

Freckled hands reach down through green-black water toward a small pale hand with open fingers.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The clock's second hand stops at 11:40. The refrigerator motor cuts out. One low tone sounds and holds.

The lamplight turns amber.

Theo opens his eyes. In the black window over the sink, his reflection sits at a table in a gold-lit kitchen. The table is scrubbed. There are no dust sheets.

The reflection is clean-shaven, its hair dry and combed. It smiles at Theo.

Theo doesn't move. The reflection stands, walks to the glass, and breathes on it. Fog spreads across the pane.

A finger writes in the fog, in the handwriting of the pages. The letters read forward to Theo:

Thank you

In the lower corner of the pane, outside, the rain streaks into the shape of a hand: palm and five fingers, spread flat.

The reflection looks at Theo and smiles. The letters run down the glass.

BLACK.

One stroke of a pencil.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MORNING

Sun pours through the window over the sink. Dust hangs in the light. The glass is clean: no fog, no letters.

Theo lifts his head from his folded arms at the table. June sits across from him, a bowl of cereal untouched in front of her, reading a cream page. A second lies beside the bowl.

JUNE
You said you were home.

THEO
I was home.

June holds up the page.

JUNE
It says you went in.

Theo reaches for it. June pulls it back.

THEO
June.

JUNE
I looked it up. People forget the worst thing that ever happened to them. Their brain puts it away. Then it comes back in pieces.

THEO
Where did you look it up?

JUNE
The internet, Dad.

She lays the page flat and smooths it with her palm.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Maybe this is your brain giving it back.

Theo looks at the page, then at her face. June sits motionless, her eyes on his mouth.

JUNE (CONT'D)
You saved Aunt Nell.

Theo opens his mouth. Closes it.

JUNE (CONT'D)
You didn't say no.

THEO
Eat your cereal.

June eats, grinning at him over the spoon.

Theo whistles two low notes, falling, as he crosses to the refrigerator for milk.

JUNE
You only do that when you're happy.

THEO
It's my father's. He used it to call us in.

He stops at the refrigerator. The photograph under the lobster magnet is different.

Theo at nine sits on a boulder at the quarry with a small girl on his shoulders. A red jacket hangs over his arm. No taller boy. No bicycle.

He lifts the magnet and takes the photo down. On the back, in faded pencil: THEO + NELL, AUG. '87. The print is yellowed, creased at one corner.

THEO (CONT'D)
There was another boy in this.

JUNE
What boy?

THEO
Tall. On a bike. Red jacket.

JUNE
That's the red jacket. It's on your arm.

THEO
That isn't mine.

JUNE
You wore it all summer. Everybody knows that.

She goes back to her cereal. Theo studies the photograph. He rubs his thumb across the small girl's face.

He smiles. He wipes the smile off his mouth with his hand. It comes back.

INT. KETTLE HOLLOW PUBLIC LIBRARY - DAY

One room: oak tables, green-shaded lamps, a microfilm reader in the corner.

A LIBRARIAN (70s), cardigan, half-glasses on a beaded chain, threads a reel onto the machine while Theo waits.

LIBRARIAN
Slate Valley News, August 1987.

She cranks the handle. Newsprint slides across the screen and stops on a front page.

BOY, 13, DIES SAVING NEIGHBOR GIRL

The photograph shows a boy in a baseball cap. Theo leans in. The face breaks into black dots.

Tomas Arvidsen of Quarry Road drowned Friday after pulling a five-year-old from the quarry pond. The girl, Eleanor Lindqvist, was treated for exposure. Her brother, Theodore, 9, was at home and did not witness the accident.

Theo reads the last line twice. He exhales.

The librarian reads over his shoulder.

LIBRARIAN (CONT'D)
Only one person ever asks for this reel. His mother, Marit Arvidsen. Every August.

She nods at an oak table by the window.

LIBRARIAN (CONT'D)
Tomas sat right there every afternoon that summer. Read everything in the juvenile stacks. Wrote in the margins in pencil. I spent half my life erasing him.

THEO
Why did you erase him?

LIBRARIAN
They're library books. I'd give a great deal to find one of those margins now.

THEO
Was he the type to jump in?

LIBRARIAN
Tomas would jump in after anybody. Didn't stop to think. That was the whole trouble with him.

Theo looks at the dots where the face should be. The librarian presses a button. A printout curls from the slot. Theo folds it into his coat.

LIBRARIAN (CONT'D)
Your sister was lucky.

THEO
So I read.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

One lamp. The laptop is open on the table. Beside it lies the library printout, face up: BOY, 13, DIES SAVING NEIGHBOR GIRL.

Two cream pages sit in front of Theo. He looks at the printout. He looks at the pages.

He turns the printout face down.

He types. The first line of page two, then the second. The pencil in the wall scratches in time with the keys. The screen reads Page 3 of 3.

He types the last word of the last page: and. His fingers keep moving. A new sentence fills the screen.

I carried her up the slate on my back. Her lips were blue. Her hair was a rope of black water.

The lamp turns amber. The scratching in the wall quickens.

I put my mouth over hers and blew, the way I'd seen it done on television. Nothing. I blew again.

Theo's shoulders drop. He grins at the screen.

She coughed the whole pond out of her and into my mouth. It tasted of iron.

The clock over the back door reads 1:12. The screen reads Page 14 of 14.

The clock reads 4:20. Page 31 of 31. The scratching and the keys match beat for beat.

She said my name. Not Theodore. Theo. The way she always said it, like a question.

Theo reaches for his mug. His sleeve slides up. On the inside of his left wrist, a line of brown-black ink surfaces under the skin, in the handwriting of the pages:

I reached.

He rubs the line with his thumb. It stays. He spits on his thumb and rubs again. It stays.

He pulls his cuff over it and keeps typing.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Rain at the window. Theo types without looking at the keys, his eyes red-rimmed.

June sits across from him with a school transfer form. Her cereal bowl is empty. She taps her pencil on the table.

In the box marked STUDENT NAME, in her neat capitals: JUNE ELISE LINDQVIST-HALE.

JUNE
Dad.

THEO
Mm.

JUNE
I need the street we lived on in the city. For the transfer form.

Theo's fingers keep moving.

THEO
Sure. It's--

His fingers stop. His lips shape the first sound of a word. No word follows.

JUNE
Perry Street.

Theo looks at her.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Where you wrote "A Room Called Afternoon." In the back bedroom, by the radiator.

THEO
"A Room Called--"

He turns toward the bookshelf. Two of his paperbacks stand there with a gap between them, wide enough for a third. June follows his eyes.

THEO (CONT'D)
"Slate." "The Understory."

JUNE
And the one in the middle.

Theo looks at the gap. He looks at June.

THEO
June, I don't--

June stands. She picks up her form and goes upstairs. Her footsteps cross the ceiling. Her voice comes through the boards, small and clear.

JUNE (O.S.)
Mom? It's me.

Theo sits. He pulls his cuff down over the line on his wrist.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The clock reads 2:07. One lamp. Theo clicks SEND on an email. The screen reads: To: Priya Raman. Subject: Pages. Attachment: 40 pages.

The clock reads 3:22. His phone buzzes across the table. PRIYA RAMAN. He answers.

THEO
Priya.

PRIYA (V.O.)
I read all forty. I'm in my kitchen in my pajamas, crying into a bowl of cereal. It's the book, Theo. It's the one you've been not writing for eight years.

THEO
It's pages.

PRIYA (V.O.)
You went into the water. You said it yourself, at the PEN dinner. Table six, 2013. You held up your hand and said, "I reached for her and she was already gone." I've been waiting twelve years for you to write it.

THEO
I never said that.

PRIYA (V.O.)
Theo. I was next to you. You squeezed my hand under the table.

Theo says nothing. His right hand is raised, palm out. He looks at it and lowers it.

PRIYA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
The board meets on the first. Whatever you're doing, keep doing it. Love you.

She hangs up. Theo sets the phone down. He pushes his sleeve to the elbow. Two lines of ink run down his forearm:

I reached.
There was nobody on the ledge.

He stares at the second line.

INT. ALDER HILL - INGRID'S ROOM - NIGHT

Night lights. Ellie opens the door. Ingrid stands at the window in a winter coat and a hat, a handbag on her arm. The bed behind her is made. She does not turn around.

Theo waits in the doorway in a wet coat.

ELLIE
She's been up since eight. She keeps asking for someone named Theodore.

Theo's eyes slide to her name tag.

THEO
That's my name.

ELLIE
I know.

INGRID
He's coming up the lane. I saw him from the window.

THEO
Who is, Mom?

INGRID
Theodore.

THEO
That's me. I'm right here.

Ingrid turns. Her eyes are steady.

INGRID
No. You're Theo. Your father saw to that.

She takes Theo's sleeve in both hands.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Don't let him finish.

THEO
Finish what?

INGRID
The sentence.

She opens her handbag and takes out a brass key tied to a faded blue ribbon. She presses it into Theo's palm and closes his fingers over it.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Under the stairs. Burn it.

THEO
Burn what, Mom?

Ingrid's hands loosen on his sleeve. She touches the brim of her hat.

INGRID
Is it Thursday?

Ellie looks at the key in Theo's fist.

ELLIE
She's held that key every night since I started here.

THEO
What does it open?

ELLIE
Ask the house. Tonight, Mr. Lindqvist. Not tomorrow.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT

The hall light is on. A steel hasp and a brass padlock hold the cellar door shut. The door sits an inch deeper in its doorway than the others.

Theo fits the key into the padlock. It turns. The hasp swings free.

He opens the door. Cold air comes up from the dark. He finds a pull-chain inside the door and tugs it. A bare bulb lights stone steps going down.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - CELLAR - NIGHT

Fourteen stone steps. A slate floor. A black iron boiler with a blue pilot flame. Shelves of dusty canning jars.

Theo reaches the bottom. Under the stairs sits a Danish butter-cookie tin, furred with dust.

He kneels and lifts the lid. Inside: a folded yellow dress printed with ducks, and a green cloth notebook. On the cover: THE MARGIN. BY THEODORE LINDQVIST. PRIVATE.

He opens the notebook. Pages of a child's pencil handwriting. In every margin, a second hand in pencil, slanted, quick:

!!
go on
what's behind the door??
best part so far

Theo's lips move over the notes. He turns to the last written page. The child's handwriting stops mid-line.

Theodore reached into the black water
and took her hand, and

The bulb flickers. It dims to orange and swings on its chain.

The blue pilot flame behind the boiler flares white.

A tall figure stands behind the boiler. Water streams from its hands and sleeves. Its face stays in the dark.

Theo steps back. His heel hits the stair.

THEO
Tomas?

The figure steps forward. A wet bare footprint forms on the slate under each foot. It raises both arms.

Theo raises the notebook between them. A wet hand closes on his wrist. Theo gasps.

The figure takes the notebook from him with its other hand and holds it open at the inside of the back cover. In pencil, in the same slanted hand as the margins:

T.A. - CHIEF READER

Water drips onto the page. The pencil does not run.

The figure pushes the notebook back into Theo's hands. Wet fingers press a small, hard object into his palm and fold his fingers closed over it.

Theo wrenches free and takes the stairs two at a time, the notebook against his chest.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT

Theo bursts through the cellar door, slams it, shoves the hasp across, and snaps the padlock shut. He leans his whole weight on the door.

On the other side: the scratch of a pencil.

He shoves his closed fist into his coat pocket. It comes out open and empty.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Theo sits at the table with the notebook and the laptop. His hands shake. A wet ring circles his wrist.

The clock reads 11:50. He opens the laptop to the pages he typed and lays the notebook beside it. He does not open the notebook.

THEO
These are mine.

He reads aloud, low and hard.

THEO (CONT'D)
"I carried her up the slate on my back. Her lips were blue."

The table slides away from him across the linoleum. His chair does not move. The table is six feet away.

THEO (CONT'D)
"Her hair was a rope of black water."

Ten feet. The back door slides away with it. The walls lean outward; the floor stretches between Theo and the table.

THEO (CONT'D)
"I put my mouth over hers and blew."

His voice sounds farther away with each line. A thread of water runs from the corner of his mouth. He keeps reading. The table is twenty feet away.

THEO (CONT'D)
"She coughed the whole pond out of her and into my--"

He coughs. Water pours from his mouth onto his shirt, onto the floor. He gasps. No air comes. He pitches out of the chair.

The table slams back into place. Dishes rattle.

Bare feet pound down the stairs. June runs in, barefoot in a long T-shirt, and drops to her knees. She rolls Theo onto his side and hits his back with the heel of her hand.

JUNE
Dad. Dad!

Water gushes from his mouth. A chip of gray slate the size of a thumbnail lands in the puddle.

Theo drags in a breath. Coughs again. Breathes.

JUNE (CONT'D)
I'm calling Mom.

THEO
No.

JUNE
I'm calling her.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Gray light. A car door slams outside. The back door opens.

MARA HALE (45) stands in the doorway: long gray coat, reading glasses pushed up into dark hair, a hard-shell case in one hand. Rain beads on her shoulders.

JUNE (O.S.)
Mom!

June runs in and hugs her. Mara holds her with one arm and keeps her eyes on Theo.

Theo sits at the table. His collar is damp. A faint blue tinge shows at the corners of his mouth.

MARA
You look terrible.

THEO
You didn't have to come.

MARA
Five hours. She called me at midnight.

JUNE
I wasn't crying.

MARA
She wasn't crying, she says.

Mara sets the case on the table. Theo's sleeves are rolled to the elbow. Four lines of brown-black ink run up his left forearm. Mara looks at them.

MARA (CONT'D)
What is that?

THEO
A pen leaked.

Mara takes his wrist and turns it to the window. She pulls a loupe from her coat pocket and bends over the ink.

MARA
That's not ink.

THEO
Mara.

MARA
It's under the skin. No inflammation, no needle marks. It sits in the epidermis the way iron-gall sits in paper.

She lets go of his wrist.

MARA (CONT'D)
Show me the pages.

Theo goes to the bookshelf and takes down SLATE. He opens it and removes page one. Mara pulls white cotton gloves from her pocket, puts them on, and takes the page by its edges.

She holds it to the window and runs a gloved thumb along the deckled edge.

MARA (CONT'D)
Cotton and linen rag. Nineteenth century. The fibers are swollen. It's wet from the inside.

She turns the page over and holds it at an angle to the light.

MARA (CONT'D)
The back is pencil. A boy's cursive, slanted right, pressed hard enough to leave a groove. I can see it. I can't read it. When I focus on the words, they're somewhere else.

She aims her phone at the page and taps. She holds the screen up to Theo: blank cream paper.

MARA (CONT'D)
And it won't photograph. You only ever read the front.

She takes the top sheet from the table and lays it beside the first.

MARA (CONT'D)
Look at the two backs.

Theo looks. On page one the pencil is dark and deep. On the sheet he copied from, it is a faint gray.

MARA (CONT'D)
Every line that comes up on you, the pencil on my pages gets lighter. You're writing over someone.

THEO
It's my handwriting.

MARA
The front is. The back isn't yours.

THEO
Then whose?

MARA
I don't know. Stop copying them.

THEO
I can't.

MARA
Can't, or won't?

Theo does not answer. Mara looks at June, then at the table.

MARA (CONT'D)
June says you were reading aloud when you drowned in your kitchen. Don't read anything aloud. I'm taking these to my lab.

THEO
Those are mine.

MARA
They're evidence of something. I don't know what yet.

She lays both pages in the case and closes it. She looks at her daughter.

MARA (CONT'D)
I came to take you home.

JUNE
I'm staying.

MARA
June.

JUNE
He can't do this by himself. I'll call you at nine. Every night.

Mara looks at her for a long moment. She looks at Theo.

MARA
Every night. I'll be back Sunday.

She kisses the top of June's head and goes out into the rain.

INT. WALTER PRUITT'S COTTAGE - STUDY - DAY

A low room with a desk, an old typewriter, a window onto the quarry road. Floor-to-ceiling shelves hold forty-one books, each by a different famous name.

Walter opens the door and looks at Theo's mouth.

WALTER
You've been reading aloud.

THEO
How do you--

WALTER
Your lips are blue.

He steps back and lets Theo in. A framed photograph stands on the desk: a woman in a wool coat on a station platform.

Theo pushes up his sleeve and shows him the arm. Walter takes his time reading it.

WALTER (CONT'D)
How many pages have you copied?

THEO
Forty.

WALTER
You signed anything?

THEO
No.

WALTER
Good. That's something.

He rolls up his own left sleeve. On the inside of his forearm, faded to pale blue, four words in a neat hand:

I DID NOT KNOW

THEO
What is that?

WALTER
My senator. 1991. Very decent man, by his own account. I wrote his memoir. Six weeks. He told me what he'd done and what he hadn't, and I typed it as he told it, and the words came up on my arm.

THEO
What did it say?

WALTER
That. "I did not know." About a night in a hospital parking lot.

THEO
Did he know?

WALTER
He knew. He signed the last page and shook my hand.

He pulls his sleeve down.

THEO
I thought it was a ghost.

WALTER
A ghost is what's left of someone who stopped. This is something else. It writes what you'd like to
(MORE)

WALTER (CONT'D)
be true, in your own hand. The more you believe it, the more of it shows. And the more of it shows, the less of what happened is left.

THEO
Left of what?

WALTER
Of whatever it's rewriting. The man I'd been writing for stopped being the man I'd met. He got warmer. Funnier. His wife wept when she told me he'd been a changed man for thirty years.

THEO
What happened to the old one?

WALTER
I've been waiting thirty-four years for somebody to tell me.

He lifts the photograph of the woman and holds it out.

WALTER (CONT'D)
My mother. I'm told. I can't remember being seven. I remember what I wrote about other men's sevens.

He sets it down.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Don't copy it. That's agreeing with your hands. Don't read it aloud. That's agreeing with your lungs. Don't sign. That's agreeing for good. I only know the rules from breaking them.

THEO
The envelope was addressed to Theodore.

Theo takes the envelope from his coat. Walter reads the name. He sits down.

WALTER
That's yours.

THEO
Nobody's used it since I was ten.

WALTER
People don't throw away their names, Theo. They leave them somewhere. And whatever you leave long enough starts answering to it.

THEO
Mara says there's writing on the back of the pages. She can't read it.

WALTER
I had one like that. Forty years in a drawer. I never turned it over. The paper went blank every time I tried.

He looks at Theo.

WALTER (CONT'D)
A page has two sides. The one you wrote and the one that held it. I used to count it out on my fingers.

He holds up a finger for each.

WALTER (CONT'D)
A line, one dimension. A page, two. A book, three. The time it takes to read it, four. Every way it might have gone, five. The sixth is the back of the page, where everything it didn't say goes.

THEO
That's a metaphor.

WALTER
It's a filing system. Whoever's holding yours has been pressing hard.

THEO
What do I do?

WALTER
Don't write tonight.

THEO
I can't not.

Walter takes a pen from the desk and puts it in Theo's hand.

WALTER
Then tell somebody something true. Out loud. Start small. It costs you something. It costs him more. He's built from one story, and a true thing is a hole in it.

THEO
True about what?

WALTER
You'll know it when you've said it.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - BATHROOM - NIGHT

A clawfoot tub, a pedestal sink, a medicine cabinet with a mirrored door. One bare bulb.

A legal pad and Walter's pen lie on the closed toilet lid.

Theo stands at the sink with his shirt off. Lines of brown-black handwriting cover his left arm and run across his ribs.

He scrubs the ribs with a nailbrush. The ink does not lighten.

He turns on the hot tap. Steam fogs the mirror.

THEO
I'm tired. I'm afraid.

Nothing changes on his skin. He wipes the glass with his palm.

His reflection does not wipe the glass. It stands with its hands at its sides. Clean-shaven, hair dry and combed, a pressed white shirt. It watches Theo.

Theo backs into the tub's edge.

REFLECTION
That's not what he meant.

Its voice is Theo's, a half step warmer.

REFLECTION (CONT'D)
You told the old man I was a ghost.

THEO
Get away from me.

REFLECTION
I haven't moved. You're the one scrubbing a sentence you wrote.

THEO
I didn't write it.

REFLECTION
You wrote forty pages. Your daughter thinks you're a hero. Your editor cried. Look at you. You're writing again.

THEO
Because of you.

REFLECTION
Because you finally listened.

Theo grips the sink.

THEO
Who are you?

REFLECTION
You know my name. You stopped saying it when you were ten.

THEO
Theodore.

THEODORE
Thank you. Nobody's said it to me in thirty-eight years.

THEO
What do you want?

THEODORE
I want to tell you what happened. You've never known. Don't you want to know?

THEO
I was home.

THEODORE
Say it like you believe it.

Theo opens his mouth. No sound comes.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
That's what I thought.

Theo sits on the edge of the tub. In the glass, the reflection sits too.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Your daughter looked at you over a bowl of cereal the way she did when she was four. Do you remember that look?

THEO
Yes.

THEODORE
No. You were writing.

Theo covers his face with his hands.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
I'm not asking you to lie. I'm asking you to let somebody be happy.

THEO
There's something in the cellar. It grabbed me.

THEODORE
I know. It's followed you since the diner. It isn't your friend. It's a bookkeeping error.

THEO
What is it?

THEODORE
Something unpaid. I can make it stop.

THEO
How?

THEODORE
One line. Everyone wants it. Nell wants it. Your mother wants it. You want it.

Theo lowers his hands.

THEO
My mother said don't let you finish.

THEODORE
She read me every night for years, Theo. Ask her what she wished.

The reflection steps to the glass and breathes on it. Fog spreads. A finger writes in the fog:

and she lived

Theo's right hand picks up Walter's pen from the toilet lid. It writes on the pad: and she lived.

Theo grips his right wrist with his left hand. The right hand keeps writing the same words, again, again, down the page.

A new line of ink surfaces along his collarbone:

and she lived

The pen drops. Theo stares at the page. He looks up.

The reflection smiles at him.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Thank you.

The bulb warms to amber. Under the floor, one long stroke of a pencil.

EXT. QUARRY TURNOUT - MORNING

Sun on wet gravel. The station wagon sits at the turnout, engine off. Theo stands at the granite slab with his left sleeve rolled down over the ink.

The inscription: TOMAS ARVIDSEN. 1974 - 1987. HE REACHED FOR HER. The plastic flowers are bleached white. A mason jar of fresh marigolds stands at the base.

Theo kneels. He traces the letters of the name with two fingers.

Gray dust sifts from under his fingertips. The letters of TOMAS ARVIDSEN crumble and slide down the face of the slab. The wind carries the dust away.

Theo snatches his hand back. His fingertips are gray.

New letters cut themselves into the granite, one stroke at a time, chips of stone flying from the surface:

THEODORE LINDQVIST
AUGUST 14, 1987
HE REACHED FOR HER

The chips settle on the gravel. The stone is whole, sharp-edged, new.

Theo stands and backs away.

A wheelbarrow rattles up the path. A SEXTON (60s) in a town maintenance vest, a bag of mulch in the barrow, stops beside Theo.

SEXTON
Morning, Mr. Lindqvist.

THEO
What happened to the name?

SEXTON
Which name?

THEO
Tomas. Tomas Arvidsen. It was right there.

SEXTON
Who's Tomas?

THEO
The boy who drowned.

SEXTON
Nobody drowned, Mr. Lindqvist. You pulled her out.

He lays a hand on the granite.

SEXTON (CONT'D)
I was here the day they set this. Whole town was. You wouldn't let go of her hand.

Theo looks at the jar of marigolds.

THEO
Somebody leaves flowers.

SEXTON
Every Friday. Never did figure out who.

The sexton holds out his hand.

SEXTON (CONT'D)
My daughter was in your sister's class. I never said thank you.

Theo looks at the hand. At the stone. He shakes it.

INT. SLATE DINER - NIGHT

Every booth is full. A hand-lettered banner hangs over the counter: WELCOME HOME, THEO. A pie sits on every table.

Theo and June stand in the doorway. The room applauds. June's face lights up. She tugs his sleeve.

JUNE
Dad. They made a banner.

A MAN (50s) pumps Theo's hand.

MAN
I was at the quarry that day. They had to pry your fingers off her hand.

A WOMAN (60s) takes Theo's wrist and turns it to the light, reading the ink.

WOMAN
I always loved this. "I reached." How old were you when you got it?

THEO
I--

WOMAN
Sixteen. You told me once. Your father was furious.

She pats his arm and moves on. The people nearby glance at the ink on his wrist and nod, and go back to their pie.

The waitress sets a slice of pie in front of Theo.

WAITRESS
On the house, hero.

In the booth by the door sits Ellie in a raincoat, a cup of coffee in front of her. She is not clapping. She is looking at Theo.

His eyes find her. Her face blurs. His eyes slide to her cup, her raincoat, the door.

Ellie stands, leaves a bill under her saucer, and walks toward the exit. She stops beside Theo. June looks up at her.

ELLIE
Funny. I don't remember it that way.

THEO
You were there?

ELLIE
I was.

She goes out. The door closes behind her. The room goes on applauding.

INT. SLATE DINER - MORNING

Theo sits alone at the counter. The diner is full again.

Every mug in the room is filled to the same line, a finger below the rim.

A man at the end of the counter lifts his mug and drinks. The level does not drop. He sets it down and lifts it again.

A MAN in one booth says, "Welcome home, Theo." A second man in another booth says it at the same moment, in the same voice. They look at each other and smile.

The clock over the register reads 7:15. Theo looks away and looks back. It reads 7:15.

Everyone in the diner turns toward him at once. They speak in one voice.

DINERS
Everything okay, Theo?

Theo drops a bill on the counter and backs out.

INT. STATION WAGON - PARKED - DAY

Theo slams the door and grips the wheel. His breath fogs the windshield.

In the rearview mirror, a man sits in the back seat.

THEODORE (47) wears a pressed white shirt. Theo's face, clean-shaven, hair dry and combed. No shadow falls on the seat beside him.

THEODORE
Good morning.

Theo does not turn around.

THEO
What did you do to them?

THEODORE
Nothing. They remember. Remembering together is easier. Look how happy they are.

THEO
The clock stopped.

THEODORE
Time is a draft too. Everything gets edited.

THEO
I want it back the way it was.

THEODORE
Was it good? Your mother in a home. Your wife in another city. Your daughter asking you to read eleven pages. I wrote a better one. Nobody's lonely in it.

Theo turns in his seat at last. Theodore smiles at him.

THEO
Where is he?

THEODORE
Who?

THEO
Tomas.

Theodore's smile holds. His throat works. He opens his mouth. Nothing comes out.

THEODORE
That--

He swallows.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
The neighbor's boy.

THEO
Say his name.

THEODORE
The boy from down the road.

THEO
His name.

Theodore breathes in through his nose. The smile stays on his face.

THEODORE
I don't need it.

THEO
You can't say it.

THEODORE
I can say anything. I choose not to.

THEO
Why can't you say it?

THEODORE
Why do you keep asking about the wet one? The other night he had his hands on you in the cellar. Did you ask what he wants?

THEO
What does he want?

THEODORE
To keep you from being happy.

Theo faces front. His hands shake on the wheel.

THEO
I won't sign anything.

THEODORE
Nobody's asking you to sign. You've typed forty pages. You're nearly home.

Theo shuts his eyes.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
I'll be there for June. I always will.

Theo opens his eyes. The back seat is empty. The cushion holds no dent.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The lamp is on. The table is set for dinner: two bowls of spaghetti, steaming.

June sits at one place. At the head of the table, in Theo's chair, sits Theodore, sleeves rolled, a napkin in his lap, his chin on his hand. He listens to June.

Theo stands in the doorway.

JUNE
--and then the lighthouse keeper finds out the whole crew is a ghost, and he has to decide whether to tell them.

THEODORE
Does he?

JUNE
That's chapter five. I haven't decided.

THEODORE
I'd tell them. Eventually. Gently.

June looks up at Theo.

JUNE
Theo, you can sit there.

She points at the foot of the table. A third place is set. The bowl is cold, a skin on the sauce.

THEO
Theo?

JUNE
Dad made spaghetti.

Theodore smiles at Theo across the table.

THEODORE
Sit. There's plenty.

Theo sits. He picks up his fork.

JUNE
Can I read you my story?

THEO
I'd love that. In a minute.

June's smile drops. She looks at her plate. Theodore lays his napkin on the table.

THEODORE
Read it to me.

June pulls her laptop toward her. She turns to Theodore and reads, her face lit.

JUNE
"Chapter One. The lighthouse had no keeper, only a lamp that wouldn't go out."

Theo watches her. At the end of every paragraph her eyes flick to Theodore. He nods each time.

June looks at Theo.

JUNE (CONT'D)
You should listen too. Dad's listening.

THEO
I'm your dad.

JUNE
I know. You're Dad too.

She smiles at him and turns back to Theodore.

Theo stands. He carries his bowl to the counter and scrapes it into the trash. He stays at the sink with his hands on the edge.

In the black window over the sink: the lamp, the table, and June reading with her whole face lit to an empty chair.

Behind him, Theodore speaks.

THEODORE
She's reading beautifully.

EXT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - PORCH - DAY

Rain. Mara stands at the foot of the porch steps in her gray coat, no case, water running from her hair. She looks up at Theo in the doorway for a long time.

MARA
I remember a flood.

THEO
What?

MARA
The storm in October. Perry Street. The water came up the basement stairs. I remember it at my knees. I remember you carrying me out and up to the street.

THEO
That never--

MARA
I know. I remember that too.

She climbs the steps and stands in front of him.

MARA (CONT'D)
I remember you standing in the doorway at three in the morning with a glass of water, not saying anything. For years. That's the one I left.

THEO
Mara.

MARA
I remember that you were a hero and I remember that you weren't. Which one did I leave?

Theo opens his mouth. Nothing comes out.

She takes a clear plastic sleeve from her coat. Two cream pages lie inside. She puts it in his hands.

MARA (CONT'D)
The pencil on the back is gone. I can't see any of it now. I only know it was there because of the groove.

She presses the heel of her hand to her forehead.

MARA (CONT'D)
Where did we meet?

THEO
What?

MARA
A café. It was raining. I've been trying since I left. It's gone.

THEO
Café Orso.

MARA
Orso.

She says it again, her lips shaping each syllable.

MARA (CONT'D)
You spilled my tea.

THEO
You said I owed you a scone.

MARA
You still do.

A laugh breaks out of her and turns into a sob. She wipes her face with her wet sleeve.

THEO
Walter said to tell somebody something true. It costs.

MARA
Then tell me.

Theo looks at his left wrist. He says it.

THEO
I don't know what I did that day.

The line on his wrist, I reached, fades to a pale gray smear, then to nothing.

In the glass of the front door behind him, the reflection of a man in a white shirt flinches and is gone.

Theo sways. Mara catches his elbow.

MARA
What did it cost you?

THEO
I don't know.

MARA
That's the worst part.

She keeps hold of his arm.

MARA (CONT'D)
I'm at the motel in Granville. Don't let June read it aloud.

THEO
She isn't reading it.

MARA
Theo. She's twelve and she's lonely and you left her with it. Don't let her read it aloud.

She lets go of his arm and walks back down the steps into the rain.

INT. WALTER PRUITT'S COTTAGE - STUDY - DAY

Rain on the window. The desk, the typewriter, the forty-one books. Walter sits in his chair, hands folded on his knee, his cardigan buttoned one hole off.

Theo stands in the doorway, wet.

WALTER
Come in. I was hoping you'd come.

THEO
I tried what you said. I told someone something true.

WALTER
Did it work?

THEO
A line went away. And something else did. I don't know what.

WALTER
That's how it works.

Walter looks at the shelves.

WALTER (CONT'D)
I think I'm going.

THEO
Going where?

WALTER
Out of everyone's memory. I've felt it since Tuesday. The spines look thinner every morning. I can read maybe thirty of the titles.

Theo steps to the shelves. The gilt on the nearest spine is faint.

THEO
I'll stop. I'll stop copying.

WALTER
You'll try. That's different.

He smiles.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Listen to me. It ends when the one who left it open says it truthfully. That's all I ever worked out. The one who left it open. And you have to say the name of the one it stole from.

THEO
Who did it steal from?

WALTER
A boy.

He closes his eyes.

WALTER (CONT'D)
It's a boy's name. I had it this morning.

The spines on the shelves go blank, one at a time. The titles fade first, then the gilt, then the cloth bleaches white.

Forty-one books, one after another, a white line moving down the shelves.

Walter watches them go.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Forty-one. I counted them every night.

THEO
Walter--

WALTER
I never put my name on anything. If you get to the end of it, put it somewhere.

The last spine goes white. Walter's hands lie open on his knees. His face goes pleasant and vague.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Can I help you?

THEO
Walter, it's Theo.

WALTER
Theo. I don't believe I've had the pleasure.

He stands, smiles, and holds out his hand.

Theo takes it. Walter's hand is not there.

The chair is empty. A dust sheet lies over it. The shelves are bare. Cobwebs hang from the desk lamp. A fur of dust covers the typewriter.

THEO
Walter?

On the floor lies the framed photograph of the woman on the station platform, its glass cracked. Theo picks it up and turns it over. In ballpoint on the back: MOTHER, 1958.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - THEO'S CHILDHOOD BEDROOM - NIGHT

A narrow bed under a slanted ceiling. A model biplane hangs from a string. A shelf of boys' adventure novels with cracked spines.

Theo sleeps in his clothes. Pencil scratching starts: the left wall, the right wall, the ceiling, the floor, all at once.

His eyes open. The scratching stops. Then it starts again, soft, under the bed.

He gets up and opens the door.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - STAIRS AND HALL - NIGHT

The house is the same house reversed. The stairs are on the right instead of the left.

The numerals on the wall clock run counterclockwise. The card on the cellar door reads RALLEC.

Theo goes down. His left hand reaches for a banister that is on his right.

Water seeps from under the cellar door and from under the white door. It runs along the baseboards toward the kitchen.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The stove stands on the opposite wall. The window over the sink is on the far side. The clock's numerals are mirror-written. The label on the cereal box reads backward.

June and Theodore sit at the table under the lamp. June reads from Theo's laptop. Theodore listens with his chin on his hand.

Water covers the linoleum to the soles of June's bare feet. She doesn't look down.

JUNE
"She was in the water before I understood she was in the water."

THEO
June.

She does not look up.

THEODORE
Shh. She's reading beautifully.

THEO
June! Stop.

JUNE
"I went in. I didn't decide to. It tasted of iron."

The water reaches Theo's ankles. The pencil scratching is a roar in the walls.

JUNE (CONT'D)
"I looked up at the ledge for someone to call. There was nobody on the ledge. I looked. I want that written down."

Theo wades toward the table. His legs drag.

JUNE (CONT'D)
"So I reached into the black water and took her hand, and she--"

A tall wet figure steps out of the dark behind June. A wet hand clamps over her mouth.

June's scream is muffled. Her heels kick.

Theo throws himself at the figure. His shoulder hits wet ribs. They crash into the stove. The figure's arms fly wide and water sprays across the kitchen.

Theo punches. His fist lands on a cold, wet body. It staggers and slides down the wall.

THEO
Let her go!

June staggers back from the table, hands at her mouth, coughing. She stares at Theo.

JUNE
Stop it! What are you doing?

THEO
It had its hand on your mouth!

JUNE
There's nothing there! You're not him!

THEO
Who?

JUNE
You're not Dad!

Theodore sits still. He watches Theo with his head tilted.

Theo looks at the wet figure on the floor. It sits slumped against the wall, hands open on its knees, its head bowed. It makes no move.

He looks at his daughter, her face white.

THEO
I'm not a hero.

JUNE
What?

THEO
I'm not a hero! I never saved anyone! She asked me to come see the door and I said "in a minute"! I didn't even look up!

The lights come on. The water is gone. The stove stands on its own wall again. The clock's numerals read forward.

The wet figure is gone. Theodore's chair is empty. The scratching is gone.

On Theo's forearm, the line There was nobody on the ledge fades to a gray smear, then to nothing.

June stands with her back against the refrigerator, breathing hard.

JUNE
That's the first page.

THEO
It's the only part I remember.

JUNE
Then who saved her?

Theo sits down on the floor where he stands.

THEO
I don't know.

June takes her phone from her hoodie pocket.

JUNE
The nurse said she was there. At the diner.

THEO
June. It's the middle of the night.

JUNE
She works nights.

She taps the screen and holds the phone to her ear. Theo watches her. He does not stop her.

EXT. QUARRY POND - NIGHT

A full moon. Slate shelves step down to the pond. Theo comes down the path with a flashlight and stops at the water's edge.

The pond is black and flat. The moon hangs in the sky. The water shows no moon.

Thirty feet out, a tall figure stands waist-deep, arms stretched out from its sides. Its mouth moves. No sound carries.

Theo clicks off the flashlight.

THEO
Tomas?

The figure's lips keep moving.

Theo picks up a stone and throws it. The stone enters the water without a splash or a ring.

The figure lowers one arm. It points past Theo, up the hill.

Theo turns. At the top of the slope, the kitchen window of the farmhouse glows amber.

He runs.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Theo bursts through the back door, soaked to the knees. The kitchen is empty. Theodore's chair is empty. The lamp burns amber.

He takes the stairs three at a time and stops in the doorway of June's room. June sleeps on her side, one hand under her cheek. The window is shut.

Theo breathes. He goes back down and sits at the kitchen table. The clock reads 3:58. Rain starts at the window.

Four knocks at the back door.

Theo crosses and opens it. Ellie stands on the step in a dripping raincoat, a framed photograph held against her chest.

ELLIE
Your daughter called the station. I walked from the highway.

She walks in. She sets the frame on the table, face up.

The photograph: Theo at nine squints on a slate ledge. A flat black pond lies behind him.

Beside him a five-year-old girl in a yellow dress printed with ducks grins at the lens, a front tooth missing.

ELLIE (CONT'D)
This hung in Mom's shadow box until Dad took it down. She kept it in the drawer by her bed.

THEO
Why do you have it?

ELLIE
Because it's mine.

Theo looks from the photograph to her face. Her face stays sharp. It does not blur. Her eyes match the girl's.

ELLIE (CONT'D)
I'm Nell.

Theo says nothing. His hand lies flat on the table.

ELLIE (CONT'D)
You never took my hand.

BLACK.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Rain on the window. The lamp burns amber.

The framed photograph lies face up on the table: a boy of nine on a slate ledge, a five-year-old girl in a yellow dress printed with ducks.

Theo sits with his hand flat beside it. The green notebook lies closed at his elbow. Nell stands in her dripping raincoat.

THEO
Tell me.

Nell pulls out the chair across from him and sits. She lays both hands flat on the table.

NELL
You were on the ledge.

THEO
I was home. I was writing.

NELL
You'd finished writing. You came to find me. You got there when Tomas had me in the middle of the pond. He was swimming us in.

THEO
I don't remember that.

NELL
He got us to the ledge. You were standing on it. You were nine. You'd run all the way.

At the head of the table, in the amber light, Theodore sits with his hands folded. Theo looks at him. Nell keeps her eyes on Theo.

NELL (CONT'D)
He pushed me up toward you. He said, "Theo, take her hand." He said it twice.

Theo's right hand lies on the table. His fingers uncurl a half inch.

NELL (CONT'D)
You put your arm out. And then you didn't.

THEO
Why?

NELL
I don't know. I was five. I was looking at your face. You were looking at him.

THEO
At Tomas.

NELL
Not at my hand. At him.

Theo's lips part. Nothing comes out.

THEODORE
She was five, Theo. Memory is a draft. I'm the fair copy.

Theo turns his head toward the head of the table. Nell watches his eyes land on the empty chair.

THEO
Be quiet.

NELL
He's here.

THEO
Yes.

NELL
Where?

THEO
At the end of the table.

Nell looks at the empty chair. Her jaw sets.

NELL
I used to be afraid of Theodore. Mom read that notebook at this table every night. "Theodore reached into the black water and took her hand, and." She said it like a prayer. I was six. I thought it was a bedtime story.

THEO
It was a wish.

NELL
She wanted a boy who took my hand. So she made one up and read him to herself until he was real enough to be afraid of.

At Theo's open collar, the brown-black line along his collarbone pales.

THEO
What happened after?

NELL
He pushed me onto the stone. I crawled out by myself. Tomas held on to the ledge with one arm. He looked at you.

THEO
What did he say?

NELL
Nothing. His arm slid off. He went under. He didn't come up.

THEO
And I--

NELL
You stood there. Until a quarry man came running. Then you walked home.

THEO
Dry.

NELL
Mom counted you in. That's what she said when they asked her. "Tomas came back wet. Theo came back dry. I counted them both in."

THEO
Both.

NELL
You and him. She counts him in every day. "One in. Two in." It was never me she was counting.

Theo shuts his eyes.

THEO
Why didn't you tell me?

NELL
I told you when I was nineteen. You said you were home. You said it so hard you stopped breathing. They kept you in a hospital for nine days. Dad said never again.

THEO
You left.

NELL
I changed my name and I left. I came back when Mom started forgetting.

THEO
Why?

NELL
Because when she forgets, there's nobody left who remembers him.

She turns the photograph and slides it toward him.

NELL (CONT'D)
His mother still leaves marigolds at the quarry every Friday. Nobody has ever told her what happened.

Theo looks at the photograph. The boy's hands hang at his sides. The girl's small hand is open, an inch from his sleeve.

From upstairs, faint, in Theo's own voice:

THEO'S VOICE (O.S.)
June. Come see the door.

Theo's head snaps toward the ceiling. Nell looks up at it. Nothing. At the head of the table, Theodore looks at Theo and smiles.

THEO
That was me.

NELL
What?

Theo is on his feet.

THEO
That was my voice. June!

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - UPSTAIRS HALL - NIGHT

Theo takes the stairs three at a time. June's door stands open. The bed is empty, the covers thrown back. The window is shut.

He checks the closet. The bathroom.

THEO
June!

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT

The front door stands open to the rain. The chain hangs loose.

Nell stands on the threshold, looking down.

On the porch boards, bare wet footprints: a child's, small, and beside them a second set, larger.

Theo comes down the stairs and stops beside her. The prints lead off the porch and across the lawn toward the quarry path, the small ones and the large ones together.

On the lawn, Theodore stands in the rain. The rain falls around him and does not touch him.

THEODORE
The wet one has her. I did ask what he wants.

Theo steps onto the porch.

THEO
That was my voice upstairs.

THEODORE
Was it? Sign, Theo. She'll wake at home with her shoes by the bed, having never left.

THEO
Where is she?

THEODORE
Where the door is.

He turns and walks toward the quarry path. The rain keeps its distance. He leaves no prints.

NELL
Who are you talking to?

THEO
Him.

NELL
Where is she?

Theo points toward the quarry. Nell looks at the prints.

NELL (CONT'D)
Those aren't just hers.

THEO
He took her.

NELL
Tomas pulled me out of that water.

THEO
You don't know what he is now.

NELL
I know what he was.

Theo shoves his hand into his coat pocket for the phone. His fingers find a thin, cold shaft.

He pulls it out: a chewed pencil, tooth marks along its length, water beading on it.

NELL (CONT'D)
That's Tomas's.

THEO
How do you know?

NELL
Teeth marks.

Theo closes his fist around the pencil. He goes back inside, takes the green notebook from the kitchen table, and pushes it into his coat.

He thumbs his phone as he runs out.

MARA (V.O.)
Theo?

THEO
June's gone. The quarry pond. Come now.

MARA (V.O.)
I'm putting my shoes on.

EXT. QUARRY POND - PREDAWN

Gray light. Fog lies on the pond. Slate shelves step down to a flat ledge at the water's edge.

On the ledge sit a pair of pink sneakers, side by side. Between the sneakers and the water, two large bare wet footprints are planted side by side, facing the sneakers.

The pond is black and flat. The paling sky does not show in it.

Theo and Nell come down the steps. Headlights swing across the rim. Mara runs down the path with a coil of yellow nylon tow rope over her shoulder.

MARA
Where is she?

THEO
In there.

MARA
In--

NELL
The pond.

Mara drops the rope and takes off her coat. She steps into the water. It reaches her ankles.

She walks ten feet out. It stays at her ankles. She stamps. Slate rings under the water.

MARA
It's solid.

NELL
It won't let you in.

THEO
It let her.

Mara wades back. She picks up the rope, loops it around Theo's waist, and ties a knot. She puts the coil in Nell's hands.

MARA
Feet braced. If it goes slack, I pull.

THEO
It won't pull me back.

MARA
I'll pull anyway.

Nell wraps the rope twice around her forearm. Mara stands behind her and takes the rope in both hands.

Theo steps to the edge of the ledge. His sneakers touch the pink ones.

He stands. His right arm rises a few inches from his side and stops, shaking.

The fog moves across the pond. Nobody speaks. A long time passes.

NELL
Theo.

He does not move.

MARA
Go.

THEO
Nell. I'm sorry.

NELL
After.

Theo steps off the ledge.

EXT. QUARRY POND - UNDERWATER - CONTINUOUS

Black water. Pale gray sheets of paper drift past Theo's face, turning, faint handwriting showing through them.

He sinks through them. They part around him and close above.

His feet touch bottom.

INT. THE VERSO - CONTINUOUS

A black floor under half an inch of water, mirroring everything above it. Theo stands on it. His clothes are dry.

The rope at his waist trails up into the dark and out of sight.

Slate shelves rise in tiers into the dark: a quarry wall with no top.

Thousands of translucent sheets of paper hang in rows from the dark, each the size of a door. Handwriting shows through them.

Gray flakes fall through the air and settle on the water without a ripple.

Theo walks. Each footstep sounds half a second before it lands.

THEO
June!

His voice comes back reversed, half a second late.

Wet bare footprints cross the black floor ahead of him, one after another, and lead between two rows of hanging sheets.

He follows them. Beyond the rows, squares of floor are lit by single hanging bulbs.

In the first square, twelve children in school clothes sit cross-legged in rows, each holding an open book. Every page is blank. They read.

The children lift their heads together and look at Theo. Then they look down at their books again.

In the second square, a man in a wedding suit stands with one hand raised to knock, his mouth open on the first syllable of a word. He does not move.

In the third, a woman in a hospital gown holds a telephone receiver to her ear. The cord ends in the air.

In the fourth, a school desk. Walter Pruitt sits at it in his cardigan, typing on a typewriter with no paper in it. The keys move. They make no sound.

Theo stops.

THEO (CONT'D)
Walter.

Walter looks up. His face is pleasant and vague.

WALTER
Can I help you?

THEO
Walter Pruitt. Forty-one books. Not a name on one of them.

Walter's hands stop above the keys. He looks at them.

WALTER
I used to know what these were for.

THEO
They wrote.

WALTER
Did they? I keep thinking there's a page.

THEO
You asked me to put your name somewhere. I will.

WALTER
Did I? That was good of me.

He smiles, nods, and goes back to typing. The keys move. They make no sound.

Theo follows the prints. At the end of the last row, a single wooden door stands alone on the black floor, with no wall around it. Amber light spills through its edges.

The prints stop at the door. Theo opens it.

INT. THE VERSO - THE STUDY - CONTINUOUS

A warm room inside the dark. Amber lamplight. The yellow rope at Theo's waist trails in behind him over the threshold.

Every wall is papered floor to ceiling in handwriting, each sentence struck through with a single line.

Theo reads a few as he enters:

I was not there.
It was my fault.
Forgive me.
I love her more than the work.

Shelves hold books in the same handwriting on their spines: SLATE, A ROOM CALLED AFTERNOON, THE UNDERSTORY.

A desk with a leather blotter, a green-shaded lamp, a fountain pen, a tray with two steaming cups of tea, and a single sheet of cream paper. A leather armchair.

In the armchair June sleeps in her pajamas, a blank book open on her lap. Her own neat capitals cover her palms: CALL MOM 9. 11 PAGES. DAD. They are fading.

Theodore sits at the desk in shirtsleeves, his hands folded.

THEODORE
Come in. Mind the tea.

Theo crosses to June. He touches her cheek. She does not wake. He lifts her hand and looks at the fading lines.

THEO
Wake her.

THEODORE
I can't. She doesn't belong to me. She belongs to the last page.

He taps the cream sheet.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Sign, and she wakes in her bed with her shoes by the door, having never left. Refuse, and she stays until she's something that stays.

Theo picks up the sheet. Brown-black handwriting covers it. At the bottom, in the same hand: Theodore Lindqvist, with a blank space beside it.

THEO
"I reached into the black water and took her hand, and she lived, and I lived, and no one else was ever in that water."

He sets it down.

THEO (CONT'D)
No one else.

THEODORE
No one.

THEO
There was a boy.

THEODORE
Sit. Have your tea. It's been a long night.

Theo does not sit.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Do you know what this room is? The back of the page, where everything it didn't say goes. Everything you dropped on the way here.

He opens a hand toward the shelves and the walls.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Perry Street. The back bedroom with the radiator. "A Room Called Afternoon," there, between the others. Your father's whistle.

Theo purses his lips. Only breath comes out.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
That's what it cost, telling Mara the truth. You did wonder. And the first sentence of "Slate."

THEO
"The kitchen smelled like wet stone."

THEODORE
I wrote that one.

THEO
I wrote that.

THEODORE
You typed it at three in the morning in a trance. You told a whole radio audience you take dictation. You never once asked who was talking.

Theo looks at the walls: the struck-through lines in the handwriting of the pages.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
I hold everything you couldn't carry. Elise, too.

THEO
Who?

THEODORE
June Elise. Your grandmother's name. You paid it the night you said "in a minute" out loud, in the kitchen, to your daughter's face. Say her name, Theo. The whole thing.

THEO
June--

His mouth works. Nothing follows.

THEODORE
You see. I'm not taking your life. I'm the part of you that's been holding it.

Theo kneels beside the armchair. He puts his forehead against June's knee.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
You were nine. You froze. Anyone would have. I'm not asking you to forget it. I'm asking you to forgive it. And the only way anyone ever forgives a thing like that is to give it a different ending. That's all a story is.

THEO
It happened.

THEODORE
It happened. And now it happened differently. Your sister doesn't have to carry your hand not coming. Your mother dies believing in you. Your daughter has a father who listens. Who loses?

THEO
The boy.

THEODORE
The boy never has to drown. Nobody has to miss him. His mother never loses him. That's the kindest line on this page.

THEO
She never has him.

THEODORE
Is that so much worse?

Theo lifts his head.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
She's in Vermont right now, asleep, with a jar of marigolds on her counter for a boy nobody remembers. Thirty-eight years of Fridays. Wouldn't you like to let her stop?

Theo says nothing. On his neck and jaw, brown-black lines surface and spread.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
One name. One line. Under mine.

He lifts the fountain pen and holds it out. Only a few faint lines are left on June's palms.

THEO
And me?

THEODORE
You'll be very happy.

Theo takes the pen. The lines climb his jaw toward his mouth. He sits at the desk. He bends over the page.

The nib touches the paper beside Theodore's printed name. Theo draws the first stroke of a T.

Theodore leans forward. His eyes shine.

Theo stops. The pen hangs over the page.

THEO
Nell said he told me to take her hand.

THEODORE
She was five.

THEO
She was there.

He lowers the pen to the desk.

THEODORE
Theo.

THEO
I stood there.

THEODORE
You were nine.

THEO
I was nine. I stood there. I had her hand in front of me and I didn't take it.

The lines on his jaw and neck lift off his skin in wisps of steam.

THEODORE
You don't know why.

THEO
No.

THEODORE
Then don't. Sign. You never have to know.

THEO
I want to know.

Theo pushes the pen aside. He picks up the cream page and turns it over.

The back is blank. Theodore rises halfway out of his chair.

THEODORE
That's scrap. Nothing is written there.

Theo tilts the page toward the green lamp. The light rakes across the paper.

Shadows fill thin grooves pressed deep into the fibers: three lines of slanted cursive, a boy's hand.

The letters stay where they are.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Put it down.

THEO
"Theo."

Gray rises into the grooves as he reads. A pencil line darkens under each word.

THEODORE
Theo. Stop.

THEO
"Take her hand."

The steam stops rising from the two cups of tea. The struck-through sentences on the walls shiver.

Theodore's arm shoots across the desk for the page. His hand stops an inch above the paper and flattens against nothing. He pushes. His arm shakes. The hand will not go down.

THEODORE
Don't.

It is a child's voice, high and thin: the voice that said "in a minute."

Theo looks up at Theodore's face.

THEO
There you are.

The shaking leaves Theodore's arm. His face smooths. He lowers himself into the chair.

THEODORE
I don't know what you mean.

Theo looks down at the page. A third line darkens under the second.

THEO
"Look."

The lamp dims. The struck-through sentences fade from the walls until the walls are tracing paper. Behind them, lit rectangles appear one at a time, a row of windows.

EXT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN WINDOW - NIGHT (REPLAY)

Rain on the outside of the glass. Behind it, the lit kitchen: Theo at the table with his eyes closed, reading aloud, smiling.

A soaked boy faces the window. His wet hand slaps the glass. Again. Again. Theo does not open his eyes.

In the pane beside Theo, his reflection leans to the glass and breathes on it. Fog spreads. A finger writes in it. From this side the letters run backward: UOY KNAHT.

The boy's hand slides down the pane. It leaves the shape of a palm and five fingers in the water.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT (REPLAY)

The hall in blue light. A tall boy walks down it, barefoot and soaked. A wet print forms under each step.

At the white door he stops. He lays his palm flat on the paint, then his forehead.

At the far end, Theo comes out of the kitchen with a mop and mops toward him, hard and fast, scrubbing out the prints one at a time.

The boy does not move. The mop reaches his heels and sweeps through his ankles.

His shoulders shake.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - CELLAR - NIGHT (REPLAY)

Theo backs against the stone steps with a green notebook raised between himself and the dark. His mouth shapes a name.

Two wet hands reach into the bulb's light. One closes on Theo's wrist and does not squeeze.

The other turns the notebook over and holds it open at the back cover: T.A. - CHIEF READER.

The hand lets go of the notebook and goes into a shorts pocket. It comes out holding a chewed pencil.

It presses the pencil into Theo's palm and folds his fingers over it, one at a time.

Theo wrenches free and runs. The stairs thunder.

The wet hands hang in the air at the height of his wrist. The fingers curl shut around nothing.

EXT. QUARRY TURNOUT - MORNING (REPLAY)

The back of the granite slab: rough, gray, unpolished. Through the stone, faint and reversed, a man kneels in the gravel and traces letters with two fingers.

A soaked boy faces the slab. He lays both palms flat on the granite and leans his weight into it.

Dust sifts down through the stone. The reversed letters slide away one at a time. New letters take their place, stroke by stroke: THEODORE LINDQVIST.

The boy's arms shake. He keeps his palms where they are.

Through the stone, a man in a vest holds out a hand to Theo. Theo looks at it. He takes it.

The boy's forehead drops against the granite.

EXT. SLATE DINER - NIGHT (REPLAY)

A wet sidewalk. Rain. A soaked boy faces the plate-glass window, rain running off his hair.

Inside, every booth is full. A banner over the counter reads WELCOME HOME, THEO. A pie on every table. A room applauding, the sound muffled to a flutter.

No one looks out.

In the booth by the door, Nell sits with her hands around a coffee cup. She is the only one not clapping.

She stands, leaves a bill under her saucer, and comes out. She passes the boy at arm's length and stops.

Her head turns an inch toward him. She turns her collar up and walks on into the rain.

The boy's head follows her until she is gone.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT (REPLAY)

The kitchen reversed: the stove on the opposite wall, water over the linoleum.

June reads aloud from a laptop, her eyes glazed, her bare feet under water. Theodore sits beside her with his chin on his hand, smiling.

A soaked boy faces the table. He steps up behind June and clamps a wet hand over her mouth. Her reading stops on the word she.

Theo's face comes at the boy out of the water, teeth bared. A fist.

The boy's head snaps sideways. He hits the stove and slides down it into the water.

He does not raise his hands. He sits with his palms open on his knees.

At Theo's shout, his head lifts.

EXT. QUARRY POND - NIGHT (REPLAY)

Moonlight. The pond, black and flat. A boy stands waist-deep thirty feet out with his arms stretched wide, facing the shore.

On the shore, Theo's flashlight clicks off. He calls across the water. His lips shape a name.

The boy lowers one arm. He points past Theo, up the hill.

At the top of the slope the farmhouse kitchen window glows amber. In it stands a man in a pressed white shirt, one hand flat on the glass, watching Theo.

Theo turns to the window. He runs for the house.

The boy's arm stays pointed at the window until Theo is out of sight.

EXT. QUARRY POND - PREDAWN (REPLAY)

Gray light. The slate ledge. A boy stands on it with his arms spread wide, facing the steps.

June comes down them in her pajamas and pink sneakers, her eyes open, her face blank. She sits on the ledge, pulls off the sneakers, and sets them side by side.

The boy steps in front of her. He shakes his head, again and again.

June stands. She does not look at him. She walks around his outstretched arm and steps off the ledge.

The black water closes over her. No ring spreads.

The boy wades in after her. At his chest the water stops him. He pushes down. The surface holds him up.

He stands in the pond with his arms stretched wide and his face turned to the hill. The farmhouse window glows amber. No one comes down.

INT. THE VERSO - THE STUDY - CONTINUOUS

The walls are thick with handwriting again. The lamp burns low. The two cups of tea are cold, a skin on each.

Theo sits with the page in both hands. Tears run down his face. He does not wipe them.

Theodore stands at the shelves with his back to the room.

THEODORE
He broke into your house. He put a hand over your daughter's mouth.

THEO
To stop her.

THEODORE
From what?

THEO
From finishing your sentence.

Theodore turns.

THEODORE
And you hit him in the face.

THEO
Yes.

THEODORE
That's who you're going to trust.

THEO
He didn't hit back.

Theodore says nothing. Theo looks at the foot of the page. A long gray smear lies there, rubbed to nothing.

THEO (CONT'D)
I want to see all of it.

THEODORE
There is no all of it. There is only what you make of it.

THEO
Show me.

He lays his palm flat on the smear. Graphite blackens the heel of his hand.

The lamp goes out.

EXT. QUARRY POND - DAY (1987)

SUPER: "3:34 P.M."

Sun on wet slate. Steam lifts off every surface.

A boy's right hand swings at his side, graphite smeared along the heel of the palm. Small sneakers run down slate steps, slapping.

At the top of the path, behind them, a bicycle lies on its side in the grass. Its front wheel spins.

The only sounds are sneakers, breath, and water.

The steps end at a flat ledge above the pond. The water is black and smooth. The sky is not in it.

On the ledge lies a red satin jacket, dropped in a heap: RUTLAND RAMS across the back in white script.

Thirty feet out, in the middle of the pond, two heads.

TOMAS ARVIDSEN (13), tall, freckled, red hair plastered to his skull, swims on his back in a gray T-shirt and cutoff shorts. One arm is locked across the chest of NELL (5).

Nell's yellow dress is dark with water. She coughs. Her eyes are wide.

Tomas lifts his head toward the ledge. His whole face goes up.

TOMAS
Theo!

He kicks. Water slaps the slate.

TOMAS (CONT'D)
Theo! Take her hand!

He reaches the foot of the ledge, hooks one arm over the stone, and hoists Nell against the slate with the other.

Her hand comes out of the water, small and open. Her fingers spread.

NELL (5)
Theo?

A boy's right hand rises into the light, graphite on the heel. It reaches down toward hers.

It stops two inches short.

TOMAS
Theo! Take her hand!

The hand shakes. It does not cross the gap.

Theo's eyes go to the red jacket beside his foot. They go to Tomas's face. They stay there.

Tomas looks up. His mouth is open on the next shout. He does not shout.

Against the sky above him, Theo's face: the mouth opens, the lips drawn back from the teeth. The eyes narrow. Both go. The face is blank.

Tomas's lips are blue. His arm shakes on the slate. He nods, small and quick.

He drives Nell up the stone with his free hand. She scrabbles over the lip on her belly and lies coughing beside Theo's sneakers.

Tomas's arm slips. His chin goes under. He comes up and looks at Theo.

He says nothing.

His arm slides off the stone. He goes under without a sound.

A ring spreads from the spot where he went under. A chewed pencil floats up through it, rolls on the black surface, and sinks.

The ring reaches the ledge and fades against the slate. Theo's sneakers are dry.

Nell sits up, shivering. She looks at her brother.

NELL (5)
Theo?

His right hand hangs in the air. It sinks to his side.

Feet pound down the steps. A QUARRYMAN (40s) in a hard hat runs past Theo without a glance, shouting, and dives off the ledge.

Water explodes. Theo does not turn.

The quarryman surfaces, gasps, and goes under again. Theo turns and walks up the steps.

At the top he passes the bicycle. The front wheel does not turn.

He walks on across the grass. His hands swing at his sides. They are dry.

INT. THE VERSO - THE STUDY - CONTINUOUS

The lamp burns low and orange. Theo's breath fogs in the cold.

He sits at the desk with his palm on the page and his eyes open. The yellow rope at his waist trails across the boards and out through the door.

Theodore stands behind the desk with his hands at his sides.

THEODORE
Did you find the reason?

Theo shakes his head.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
I looked, Theo. Thirty-eight years and every draft. There isn't one. You looked at his jacket and then at his face and you stopped.

THEO
I know.

THEODORE
Let me give you one. Fear. Shock. Grief. I'll write it so well you'll weep when you read it.

THEO
No.

THEODORE
You'll spend the rest of your life not knowing.

THEO
Yes.

THEODORE
Nobody can live like that.

THEO
Then I'll be a man who doesn't know.

He lifts his palm. The gray smear at the foot of the page sharpens into three lines of slanted cursive in fresh, dark graphite.

He reads them aloud.

THEO (CONT'D)
"You don't have to be brave."

His voice catches.

THEO (CONT'D)
"You just have to be quick."

Theodore's mouth opens. Nothing comes out.

THEO (CONT'D)
"Say my name when you tell it."

THEODORE
He's a boy who drowned. He can't forgive you.

THEO
He didn't write "forgive."

Theo takes the green notebook from inside his coat and opens it on the desk to the last written page. A child's pencil handwriting, round and careful:

Theodore reached into the black water and took her hand, and

He takes out the chewed pencil. Tooth marks run the length of it.

THEODORE
If you write that, you're on the record. Priya. The board. Every reader you ever had. A man who stood there.

THEO
Yes.

THEODORE
And June?

Theo looks at June. She sleeps in the armchair, her palms white.

THEO
She knows. I told her in the kitchen.

THEODORE
You don't know what happens to her if you do this.

THEO
No. I know what happens if I sign.

He strikes a line through THEODORE. Above it, in his own hand, he writes:

Tomas Arvidsen, thirteen,

He bends to the end of the line and writes on. His lips move with the pencil.

she lived, and he did not, and I stood there.

Theodore leans across the desk.

THEODORE
Write it if you have to. Don't read it aloud.

THEO
That's the part that counts.

THEODORE
Theo.

Theo reads.

THEO
"Tomas Arvidsen, thirteen, reached into the black water and took her hand, and she lived, and he did not, and I stood there."

The last word leaves his mouth. The Study goes silent.

The brown-black lines on Theo's collarbone and ribs lift off his skin and rise through his open collar in curls of steam.

Between his shoulder blades a pencil scratches across his back, slow and firm, one long line and then another. He arches, one hand reaching behind him.

On the shelves, the spines go white one at a time: SLATE. A ROOM CALLED AFTERNOON. THE UNDERSTORY. The shelves stand full of blank white books.

Theodore looks at the shelves. He looks at his own hands. The edges of his fingers go gray.

THEODORE
You will never write a sentence like mine again.

THEO
No.

THEODORE
They'll notice.

THEO
Let them. I'll tell them why.

Black water seeps up between the floorboards. It spreads under the desk and the armchair.

Theo gets up and crosses to June. He kneels and takes her hand.

THEO (CONT'D)
June.

Her eyelids do not move.

THEO (CONT'D)
June Elise--

His mouth stays open on the second name. Nothing follows.

THEO (CONT'D)
June...

The yellow rope at his waist trembles. Voices come out of its strands, thin and flat.

MARA (V.O.)
June Elise Lindqvist-Hale!

NELL (V.O.)
June! June Elise!

Theo looks at the rope. He looks at June.

THEO
June Elise Lindqvist-Hale.

Her fingers curl around his.

The water reaches the legs of the armchair. The chair lifts. Her hand slips out of his.

The walls come loose. The sheets of struck-through handwriting peel away and drift up into the dark. The shelves and the ceiling go with them.

The flood climbs past the knees, the waist, the chest. The armchair spins away across the floor, tips, and drops June under the water.

THEO (CONT'D)
June!

He plunges after her. The current throws him back against the desk. He claws up onto it and kneels on the blotter, streaming.

The desk is an island, its top level with the water. The green-shaded lamp burns on it, a pool of orange light on flat black water.

Nothing breaks the surface.

THEO (CONT'D)
June!

At the edge of the light, the water bulges.

A boy wades into the lamplight, chest-deep, with June held against him. Her head rests on his shoulder. Her face is clear of the water.

It is Tomas: thirteen, freckled, red hair plastered down, a purple bruise on his cheekbone.

He lifts her toward the desk.

TOMAS
Take her hand.

Her small hand hangs open in the air past the edge of the desk.

Theo's right hand reaches for it. It shakes. It stops two inches short.

TOMAS (CONT'D)
Take her hand.

Theo looks at Tomas's face. He does not move.

THEO
Now.

His hand crosses the two inches and closes on hers.

He hauls. June comes up out of the water into his arms, limp and streaming. He lays her on the blotter and turns her on her side.

She coughs up water. Her eyes open.

JUNE
Dad?

THEO
I'm here.

She grips his sleeve with both hands.

Tomas hooks one arm over the edge of the desk. His chin rests on the wood. His arm shakes.

He looks up at Theo.

Theo goes down on his stomach on the blotter and holds out his hand.

THEO (CONT'D)
Tomas.

Tomas looks at the hand.

It does not shake.

Tomas takes it.

Theo hauls. It takes his whole back. Tomas comes up over the edge of the desk and falls on his side on the blotter, gasping.

The water stops running off him. His hair dries from the roots out. His shirt dries. He sits up and plucks at his own dry sleeve.

THEO (CONT'D)
I hit you.

Tomas touches the bruise on his cheekbone. He shrugs. A lopsided grin splits his freckled face.

Theo laughs, a cracked sound, and wipes his face with his wrist.

The flood drains out through the floor with a long sucking sound. Black boards shine under the lamp. The walls are gone. The shelves are gone.

Gray flakes drift down out of the dark and settle on the boards.

Theodore stands alone in the middle of the floor in his pressed white shirt. The shirt is dry. A seam runs up his collar and across his jaw, gray inside.

He looks at the three of them on the desk.

THEODORE
I only wanted to be the one who did it.

Theo stands, June against his side.

THEO
So did I.

Theodore's face loosens. He looks at Tomas. His throat works.

THEODORE
Tomas.

Tomas lifts his chin.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Thank you.

He holds out his right hand, palm up. A thread of brown-black ink uncurls from his fingertips and crosses the air to Theo's open hand.

It touches Theo's palm, sinks into the skin, and is gone.

The rest of Theodore comes apart in gray flakes: hand, arm, shoulders, face. The flakes fall to the boards and lie there.

Theo closes his hand.

Tomas picks up the green notebook and the chewed pencil from the blotter. He slides the notebook inside Theo's coat.

He takes Theo's free hand, lays the pencil in the palm, and folds the fingers over it, one at a time.

Theo lets him.

The yellow rope snaps taut at Theo's waist. It drags him backward off the desk with June in his arms. His heels leave the desktop.

Tomas stands on the desk with his hands in his pockets, gray flakes settling on his dry hair and shoulders.

His lips shape two words: Go on.

INT. THE VERSO - ASCENDING

The rope hauls Theo and June up through the dark, past the rows of hanging sheets. The sheets are blank and white.

Below them, the squares of floor are lit by single bulbs. In each square a gesture finishes.

The twelve children close their books and stand together.

The man in the wedding suit knocks. A door appears under his knuckles and swings open on a lit room and music.

The woman in the hospital gown lifts the receiver. The cord runs to a wall. She says hello and smiles.

At the school desk, Walter Pruitt's typewriter strikes a key. It makes a sound.

A sheet of paper rolls up out of it, typed across the top: BY WALTER PRUITT. Walter looks up into the dark and raises one hand.

Far below, between the squares, a boy walks away across the gray silt with his hands in his pockets. Dry footprints form behind him, one at a time.

EXT. QUARRY POND - DAWN

Gray light, fog on the water. Mara and Nell stand braced on the ledge with the yellow rope taut between them.

Mara's palms are raw. Nell's forearm is wrapped in rope to the elbow.

The rope jerks. They haul, hand over hand.

The pond breaks. Theo's head and shoulders come up, gasping, June against his chest. Her hair streams. Her eyes are open.

Mara drops her end of the rope and steps off the ledge. The water takes her to the knees, the thighs, the waist.

She takes June out of his arms.

MARA
Breathing. She's breathing.

She carries June up onto the slate, lays her on the coat she left there, and wraps it around her. June coughs. Mara chafes her arms.

JUNE
Mom?

MARA
I've got you.

Theo wades to the ledge. His arms shake. The slate lip stands at his chest, wet and steep.

Nell kneels at the edge and holds out her hand.

Theo looks at it. His own hand does not shake. He takes hers.

THEO
Nell.

NELL
After.

THEO
It's after.

Nell looks at him a long moment.

NELL
Yes. It is.

She hauls. He comes up over the lip onto the slate on his stomach and lies there with the water running off him.

June lies wrapped in Mara's coat, teeth chattering. She turns her head toward him.

JUNE
Dad.

THEO
I'm here.

JUNE
Who saved her?

Theo looks at Nell. He looks back at June.

THEO
His name was Tomas Arvidsen. He was thirteen.

JUNE
Tomas Arvidsen.

THEO
Yes.

June's eyes move to Nell.

JUNE
Aunt Nell?

NELL
Hi, June.

June closes her eyes.

Nell pulls Theo's sodden coat and shirt up his back. Between his shoulder blades, in slanted pencil:

T.A. - CHIEF READER

Water streams over it. The pencil does not run.

NELL (CONT'D)
What is that?

THEO
What does it say?

NELL
T.A. Chief reader.

Theo puts his forehead down on the slate.

THEO
Tomas Arvidsen.

Nell lays her palm flat over the letters and leaves it there.

Mara kneels beside June with one hand on her daughter's hair. She looks across at Theo. He lies with his face turned to the sky.

THEO (CONT'D)
Perry Street.

MARA
What?

THEO
The radiator. It knocked all night.

A laugh bursts out of her.

MARA
You told me it was ghosts.

THEO
You told me it was the boiler.

MARA
It was the boiler.

THEO
I know.

MARA
Café Orso.

THEO
I owe you a scone.

MARA
You owe me several.

She gathers June up in the coat.

MARA (CONT'D)
Get up. She's getting checked, and so are you.

Nell takes Theo's arm and pulls him to his feet.

The fog lifts off the pond. The paling sky lies in the water: the pines, a smear of pink, the last star.

Nell looks down at it. Nobody speaks.

INT. ALDER HILL MEMORY CARE - DAYROOM - DAY

Rain on the glass doors and the garden beyond them. The man at the window, hands clasped behind him.

The two women at the table with a jigsaw puzzle, one piece missing. The woman with the walker in the doorway.

Ingrid sits at the corner table folding washcloths. A basin of water at her elbow. She dips a cloth, wrings it, folds it in thirds, stacks it.

INGRID
One in. Two in.

Theo comes in from the rain, hair dripping, his coat dark with water. Nell follows him.

He crouches beside Ingrid's chair.

THEO
Mom.

Ingrid looks up. She cups his wet face in her hands.

INGRID
Tomas! Look at--

She stops. Her thumbs move on his cheekbones.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Theo.

THEO
Yes.

INGRID
You're wet.

THEO
I went in the water, Mom.

INGRID
Theo came back wet.

At the word "wet," everyone in the room turns toward the glass doors. The man at the window. The two women. The woman with the walker.

Then, together, they turn and look at Theo. The man at the window nods.

Theo covers his mother's hands with his own.

Ingrid's eyes move past him to the woman standing at his shoulder.

INGRID (CONT'D)
He sees you now.

Nell does not answer. Her chin shakes.

Ingrid takes a cloth from the basin, wrings it, folds it in thirds, and stacks it.

INGRID (CONT'D)
One in.

She does it again.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Two in.

She dips a third cloth. She wrings it and folds it. She holds it out to Nell.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Three in.

Nell takes the cloth. She presses it against her mouth.

EXT. QUARRY TURNOUT - MORNING

SUPER: "FRIDAY"

Sun on wet gravel. The station wagon sits at the turnout, engine off. Theo stands in front of the granite slab with his hands at his sides.

The marigolds in the mason jar at its base are brown.

The inscription is whole again:

TOMAS ARVIDSEN
1974 - 1987
HE REACHED FOR HER

Gravel crunches. MARIT ARVIDSEN (82) comes along the path in rubber boots and a quarryman's wool cap, a canvas bag on her arm.

Her face is broad and weathered, the freckles gone to age spots. She stops at the edge of the gravel and looks at him.

MARIT
You're the Lindqvist boy.

THEO
Yes, ma'am.

She comes to the slab. She sets down the bag, takes the old jar, empties it onto the gravel, and fills it from a thermos.

She takes fresh marigolds from the bag and arranges them. She does not look at him.

MARIT
You've been standing there a while.

THEO
I came to tell you something.

MARIT
Then tell it.

Theo's hands open and close at his sides.

THEO
On the fourteenth of August, 1987, your son swam my sister to the ledge. I was standing on it. He told me to take her hand.

Marit's hands stop on the flowers.

THEO (CONT'D)
I didn't.

A bird calls somewhere in the pines.

MARIT
They said you were home.

THEO
I wasn't.

MARIT
Thirty-eight years, they said you were home.

THEO
I know.

She turns and looks at him for the first time.

MARIT
How old were you?

THEO
Nine.

MARIT
He was thirteen.

THEO
Yes.

MARIT
Did he say anything? At the end.

THEO
No. He looked at me. He nodded.

Marit's mouth shuts hard. She turns to the stone and lays her hand on the granite.

THEO (CONT'D)
Tomas chewed pencils to splinters. He wrote in the margins of everything I wrote. He was the best reader I ever had.

He takes the green notebook and the chewed pencil from inside his coat and holds them out.

THEO (CONT'D)
These are his. I'm sorry.

Marit takes the notebook. She opens it. In the margin beside a child's handwriting, in pencil:

best part so far

Her thumb moves over the words. Her lips move with them.

She takes the pencil. Her thumb finds the tooth marks.

MARIT
He ruined every one.

She holds the pencil against her chest.

MARIT (CONT'D)
Say it again.

THEO
Tomas.

MARIT
Again.

THEO
Tomas Arvidsen.

Her eyes close.

MARIT
Thank you for saying it.

She takes his hand in both of hers and holds it. He lets her.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DUSK

The dust sheets are gone. The window over the sink stands open. Wet leaves lie on the sill. Beyond it, the FOR SALE sign lies face down in the grass.

Through the doorway to the hall: at the far end, the white door stands open, paint chips on the floorboards in front of it.

Inside, a narrow bed with a white coverlet, a duffel bag, and a folded yellow dress printed with ducks on the pillow.

NELL (O.S.)
Dinner in ten.

On the bookshelf, three paperbacks stand together, titles legible, spines aligned. There is no gap.

On the refrigerator door, a sticky note in June's block capitals: CALL MOM 9.

Theo sits at the table with a pencil and a new spiral notebook. On its cover, in June's neat block capitals: THEO - BOOKS (DO).

Beside it lies the old photograph from the refrigerator: Theo at nine, and a taller boy on a bicycle in a red jacket.

The boy's face is clear: freckled, grinning, a pencil behind his ear.

His laptop is open, the screen dark.

His sleeves are rolled to the elbow. His forearms are bare.

He listens to the wall behind the stove. No scratching. He nods, small and quick.

His phone buzzes on the table. A voicemail from WALTER PRUITT. He taps the speaker.

WALTER (V.O.)
Theo. Walter Pruitt. I seem to have been mislaid for some days and found again on my own doorstep, which I'm told reflects well on
(MORE)

WALTER (V.O.) (CONT'D)
someone's housekeeping. There are forty-one books on my shelves. I'd be obliged if you rang me. And I understand you owe me a name.

The corner of Theo's mouth lifts. He opens the notebook to the first page and writes.

For Walter Pruitt

He turns the page and writes in plain letters.

I was nine. I don't know why I didn't move.

He reads it aloud, low.

THEO
"I was nine. I don't know why I didn't move."

Nothing happens. The ink stays on the paper. His forearm stays bare.

He breathes out. He picks up the phone and dials. It rings twice.

PRIYA (V.O.)
Theo?

THEO
You asked me for one sentence.

PRIYA (V.O.)
I asked for pages.

THEO
I know. I have one.

He reads it to her. A long silence on the line.

PRIYA (V.O.)
That's not like you.

THEO
No.

PRIYA (V.O.)
...Send me the second.

Theo hangs up. He bends over the notebook and the pencil starts the second line. Under his breath he whistles two low notes, falling.

June appears in the doorway with her laptop held against her chest.

JUNE
You're whistling.

Theo's pencil keeps moving. It stops in the middle of a word.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Can I read you my story?

Theo sets the pencil down across the page.

THEO
Now.

He pushes the notebook aside. June crosses the kitchen, pulls out the chair across from him, and opens the laptop.

JUNE
"Chapter One. The lighthouse had no keeper, only a lamp that wouldn't go out."

She reads on, her whole face lit. Theo listens, his whole face turned to her.

At the end of the paragraph her eyes flick up to him. He nods, small and quick.

She smiles and reads on.

EXT. QUARRY POND - DUSK

The pond at dusk, flat and smooth. The last pink in the clouds, the dark line of the pines, and the first star lie in the water.

A ring spreads outward from the center of the pond, slow and wide. Nothing disturbs the water above it.

The ring reaches the ledge. It laps the slate and is gone.

BLACK.

THE END